PUNJAB WOMEN'S LEGAL PROTECTION AND RIGHTS HANDBOOK

Laws, rights, procedures, complaint forums and helplines for women in Punjab, Pakistan

Covers: violence, domestic abuse, harassment, cybercrime, acid attacks, marriage, divorce, dower, maintenance, inheritance, property, loans, workplace rights, health, and child protection.

Prepared as a practical legal-reference compilation.
For legal advice or an emergency, contact the helplines listed in this handbook.

How to use this handbook

This handbook is organised by real-life situation, then by law. Each chapter identifies the applicable law, the key sections, the remedy available, and the forum where a complaint or case should be filed.

Punjab-specific laws are given priority. Federal laws that apply throughout Pakistan, including Punjab, are included where they protect women.

For complete official texts, use the Punjab Laws Online database and the official gazette notifications. This handbook includes source links so every law can be verified and expanded into a full-text edition.

Part A — Core Punjab women-protection laws

1. Punjab Protection of Women against Violence Act, 2016

Official source: https://natlex.ilo.org/dyn/natlex2/natlex2/files/download/102088/PAKD102088.pdf

Scope: The main Punjab law for domestic, sexual, psychological, verbal, economic, stalking and cyber violence against women.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Section 2: Definitions — aggrieved person, domestic violence, economic abuse, emotional/psychological/verbal abuse, stalking, cybercrime.
- Section 3: Establishment of Women Protection Officers and district-level protection mechanisms.
- Section 4: Duties of Women Protection Officers — receiving complaints, risk assessment, assistance, coordination with police and courts.
- Section 5: Complaint procedure — direct complaint to court or through Women Protection Officer.
- Section 6: Interim orders — immediate protection where risk exists.
- Section 7: Protection orders — restraining abuser, prohibiting contact, protecting the victim.
- Section 8: Residence orders — right to reside in shared household; protection from eviction.
- Section 9: Monetary orders — compensation, loss of earnings, medical expenses, maintenance-related relief.
- Section 10: Custody-related protections where relevant.
- Section 11: Counselling, rehabilitation and shelter support.
- Section 12: Duties of police, medical officers and other officials.
- Section 13: Violence Against Women Centres — integrated reporting, FIR, medical, forensic, counselling, legal aid and shelter services.
- Section 14–15: District Women Protection Committees and monitoring.
- Section 16–20: Court procedure, appeals, jurisdiction and implementation.
- Section 21–31: Penalties, breach of orders, rules, repeal and transitional provisions.

Punjab practice point: A woman facing violence from a husband, in-laws, sibling, parent, employer, neighbour or acquaintance can seek protection under this Act. Stalking and cybercrime are expressly included within the Act's scope.

2. Punjab Women Protection Authority Act, 2017

Official source:
https://jppbenchbook.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/11/The-Punjab-Women-Protection-Authority-Act-2017.pdf

Scope: Creates the institutional body responsible for implementing women-protection policy and coordinating district mechanisms.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Establishment and composition of the Punjab Women Protection Authority.
- Functions: policy, monitoring, coordination, awareness, capacity-building and oversight.
- District Women Protection Committees.
- Coordination with police, health, social welfare, judiciary and local government.
- Power to make rules and issue implementation directions.

Part B — Harassment and workplace protection

3. Protection Against Harassment of Women at the Workplace Act, 2010, as amended in 2022

Official source: https://fospah.gov.pk/SiteImage/Misc/files/PAHAW_amend_2022.pdf

Scope: Applies to public and private workplaces, educational institutions, and other organisations in Punjab.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Section 2: Definitions — harassment, workplace, employee, employer, complainant, respondent.
- Section 2A/3: Prohibited conduct and scope — unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favours, verbal, non-verbal, written or physical conduct creating a hostile environment.
- Section 3: Mandatory Inquiry Committee in every organisation.
- Section 4: Competent authority and employer responsibilities.
- Section 5: Procedure for inquiry — complaint, inquiry, confidentiality, opportunity to respond.
- Section 6: Powers of Inquiry Committee.
- Section 7: Penalties and disciplinary action.
- Section 8: Complaint to Ombudsperson where the complainant is dissatisfied or where no committee exists.
- Section 9–12: Ombudsperson procedure, appeals, confidentiality and implementation.

Forum: First complain to the workplace Inquiry Committee. If unavailable, biased, delayed, or unsatisfactory, file directly with FOSPAH. FOSPAH is a quasi-judicial body and can issue legally binding decisions.

4. Punjab Protection against Harassment of Women at the Workplace (Amendment) Act, 2012

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Punjab amendment aligning provincial implementation with the federal harassment framework.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Provincial adaptation of workplace-harassment machinery.
- Ombudsperson and Inquiry Committee implementation in Punjab organisations.
- Employer obligations and complaint procedure.

Public-place harassment

Public harassment, stalking, obscene gestures, sexual comments, following, touching, and intimidation are also criminal offences under the Pakistan Penal Code. A woman may report at the nearest police station and may also seek protection under the Punjab Protection of Women against Violence Act where the conduct amounts to stalking or harassment.

Part C — Criminal protection: violence, acid attacks, rape, honour crimes

5. Pakistan Penal Code, 1860 — women-related offences

Official source: https://www.punjablaws.gov.pk/

Scope: General criminal law applying in Punjab. Include only women-relevant sections in the mega PDF, not the entire Code.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Section 294: Obscene acts and songs in public.
- Section 295A / 298: Insulting religious feelings and related public-order offences, where applicable.
- Section 324: Attempted murder — relevant in acid attacks and serious violence.
- Section 326 / 326A–326B: Causing hurt by dangerous means; acid crime provisions after amendments.
- Section 337: Hurt and injury provisions.
- Section 337E: Acid crime and related punishment provisions.
- Section 375–376: Rape and punishment for rape.
- Section 376A–376E: Rape-related aggravated offences, gang rape, custodial rape and related matters.
- Section 354: Assault or criminal force to woman with intent to outrage her modesty.
- Section 354A: Assault or use of criminal force to woman and stripping her of clothes.
- Section 354B: Vitiating atmosphere for woman, including assault to outrage modesty.
- Section 354C: Voyeurism — watching or capturing private acts without consent.
- Section 354D: Stalking.
- Section 365–365B: Kidnapping, abduction, forced marriage and related offences.
- Section 366A: Procuration of minor girl.
- Section 366B: Importation of girl from foreign country.
- Section 493–498: Marriage-related offences, deceitful means, enticing or taking away for illicit purposes.
- Section 496A: Fictitious marriage ceremony.
- Section 498A: Kidnapping or abducting woman to compel her to marry.
- Section 498B: Prohibition of forced marriage.
- Section 506: Criminal intimidation — relevant for threats and blackmail.
- Section 509: Insulting modesty, sexual harassment and related conduct.
- Section 499–500: Defamation — relevant for false accusations and reputation attacks.
- Section 463–477A: Forgery, forged documents and using forged documents — relevant to fake nikahnama, fake divorce papers and fraudulent property documents.

6. Acid Control and Acid Crime Prevention Act, 2011

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: National law applying in Punjab; regulates acid sales and criminalises acid violence.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Regulation of sale, purchase, storage and handling of acid.

- Licensing requirements for acid sellers and dealers.
- Criminal liability for throwing or administering acid.
- Compensation and treatment obligations for victims.
- Coordination among police, health departments and regulatory authorities.

Acid-attack response: Preserve clothing and evidence, obtain immediate medico-legal examination, request police registration of FIR, and seek treatment and compensation through the relevant hospital, police, and legal-aid channels.

7. Criminal Law (Amendment) (Offence of Rape) Act, 2016

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Amendments strengthening rape investigation, evidence, protection and punishment.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Expanded definition and procedural safeguards for rape survivors.
- Medico-legal examination and forensic evidence safeguards.
- Protection of survivor identity and dignity.
- Faster trial and investigation safeguards.
- Enhanced punishment for rape and gang rape.

8. Criminal Law (Amendment) (Offences in the Name or Pretext of Honour) Act, 2016

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Closes loopholes that previously allowed compromise in honour-based killings.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Criminalisation of offences committed in the name or pretext of honour.
- Restrictions on compromise and pardon in honour-crime cases.
- Enhanced punishment and procedural safeguards.
- Protection for survivors, witnesses and family members at risk.

Part D — Online crime, fake pictures, blackmail and deepfakes

9. Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act, 2016

Official source: https://www.fia.gov.pk/files/publications/860464251.pdf

Scope: Federal cybercrime law applying in Punjab; central law for online harassment and image-based abuse.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Section 16: Unauthorized access to information systems.
- Section 17: Unauthorized copying or transmission of data.
- Section 18: Interference with information systems.
- Section 19: Unauthorized access to critical infrastructure.
- Section 20: Cyberstalking and harassment through information systems.
- Section 21: Offences against modesty of a natural person and minor — non-consensual intimate images, sexually explicit content, superimposed faces/deepfakes, blackmail using intimate material.
- Section 22: Hate speech and related online speech offences.
- Section 24: Cyberstalking — repeated contact, monitoring, tracking and intimidation.
- Section 25: Spamming.
- Section 26: Spoofing — relevant to fake caller IDs and impersonation.
- Section 27: Unauthorized interception of transmission.
- Section 28: Cyber terrorism.
- Section 29–31: Electronic forgery, electronic fraud and related offences.
- Section 37–38: Powers to block/remove unlawful content and preserve data.
- Section 45–48: Investigation, complaints, international cooperation and procedural provisions.

Immediate action: Do not delete chats, images, URLs, account names, call records or payment demands. Screenshot everything, preserve metadata where possible, report to FIA Cybercrime at 1991, and file a police complaint if there is physical danger.

Part E — Marriage, divorce, dower, maintenance and family rights

10. Muslim Family Laws Ordinance, 1961

Official source: https://www.punjablaws.gov.pk/

Scope: Core Muslim family law in Punjab for nikah, dower, divorce and registration.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Section 5: Registration of marriages.
- Section 6: Polygamy — permission and procedure.
- Section 7: Talaq — notice, procedure and effectiveness.
- Section 8: Dissolution of marriage otherwise than by talaq.
- Section 9: Maintenance.
- Section 10: Dower.
- Section 11: Power to make rules.
- Section 12: Penalty for contraventions.

11. Dissolution of Muslim Marriages Act, 1939

Official source: https://www.punjablaws.gov.pk/

Scope: A woman's right to seek judicial dissolution of marriage.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Section 2: Grounds for dissolution — cruelty, desertion, failure to maintain, impotence, insanity, leprosy, virulent disease, option of puberty and other grounds.
- Section 3: Notice to heirs where husband is missing.
- Section 4: Effect of apostasy.
- Section 5: Dower not to be forfeited in certain cases.
- Section 6: Reconciliation procedure before decree.

12. Punjab Muslim Family Laws (Amendment) Act, 2015

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Punjab amendment to strengthen family-law implementation.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Amendments to marriage registration and nikah procedures.
- Strengthened penalties for violations of family-law requirements.
- Improved enforcement of women's family-law rights.

13. Punjab Family Courts (Amendment) Act, 2015

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Improves access to Family Courts for family disputes.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Jurisdiction of Family Courts in marriage, dower, maintenance, custody, guardianship and dissolution cases.

- Pre-trial and reconciliation procedure.
- Time-bound proceedings and case-management reforms.
- Appeal and enforcement mechanisms.

14. Punjab Marriage Restraint (Amendment) Act, 2015

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Punjab law addressing underage marriage.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Minimum marriage-age framework and penalties.
- Liability of parents, guardians, nikah registrars and persons conducting underage marriages.
- Court powers to prevent or annul underage marriage.
- Protection and rehabilitation of affected girls.

15. Prevention of Anti-Women Practices Act, 2011

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: National criminal-law amendment applying in Punjab.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Prohibition of forced marriage.
- Prohibition of marriage with the Holy Quran.
- Prohibition of depriving a woman of inheritance.
- Prohibition of coercive marriage practices.
- Criminal penalties for offenders and facilitators.

16. Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929 and Punjab amendments

Official source: https://www.punjablaws.gov.pk/

Scope: Historic federal framework as amended and applied in Punjab.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Minimum age for marriage.
- Punishment for contracting, arranging or facilitating child marriage.
- Liability of guardians and nikah registrars.
- Court powers to restrain child marriage.

Part F — Property, inheritance, loans and financial rights

17. Punjab Enforcement of Women Property Rights Act, 2021

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Punjab's dedicated law for restoring women's possession of property taken through fraud, coercion or inheritance denial.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Right of women to seek restoration of immovable property.
- District-level enforcement mechanism and designated officers.
- Procedure for complaints where property has been usurped or transferred fraudulently.
- Powers to restore possession and cancel unlawful transactions.
- Protection from coercion, forgery, and fraudulent transfer.
- Appeal and review remedies.

18. Punjab Partition of Immovable Property (Amendment) Act, 2015

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Improves women's ability to claim and partition inherited immovable property.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Partition rights of female heirs.
- Court procedure for division of inherited property.
- Protection against delay and manipulation in partition cases.

19. Punjab Land Revenue Act, 1967, including 2012 amendments

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Relevant to land records, inheritance entries, mutation, and property possession.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Record-of-rights and mutation entries.
- Inheritance mutation and transfer of ownership.
- Revenue-officer jurisdiction over land-record disputes.
- Safeguards relevant to fraudulent mutation or illegal dispossession.

Loans, credit and financial protection

There is no single "Women's Loan Act." Women's loan and credit rights arise from contract law, banking law, microfinance rules, State Bank regulations, and social-protection programmes. In a women's-rights handbook, include: contract-law protections, prohibition of coercive recovery, banking complaint procedures, microfinance regulations, and government loan schemes for women entrepreneurs.

Relevant areas to compile: Contract Act, 1872; Financial Institutions (Recovery of Finances) Ordinance, 2001; State Bank of Pakistan regulations; Punjab Small Industries Corporation / women-entrepreneur loan schemes; Benazir Income Support Programme and social-protection rules.

Part G — Health, maternity, employment and social protection

20. Maternity Benefit Ordinance, 1958 / Punjab employment protections

Official source: https://www.punjablaws.gov.pk/

Scope: Protects maternity-related employment rights for women workers.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Maternity leave and maternity benefit.
- Prohibition of dismissal during maternity leave.
- Employer obligations regarding wages and leave.
- Enforcement through labour authorities.

21. Punjab Fair Representation of Women Act, 2014

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Promotes women's representation in public institutions and decision-making bodies.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Minimum representation requirements for women in public bodies.
- Appointment and nomination safeguards.
- Monitoring of women's participation in public institutions.

22. Punjab Restriction on Employment of Children Act, 2016 and Punjab Prohibition of Child Labour at Brick Kilns Act, 2016

Official source: https://pcsw.punjab.gov.pk/womens_rights

Scope: Protects girl children from exploitative labour.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Prohibited forms of child labour.
- Minimum-age protections.
- Penalties for employers.
- Inspection and enforcement mechanisms.

Health-related legal protections

Women's health rights are protected through a combination of constitutional rights, medical ethics, criminal law, and health-service regulations. Include: right to emergency medical treatment, medico-legal examination after sexual violence, confidentiality of medical records, informed consent, prohibition of unethical medical practice, and access to maternal-health services.

Relevant materials: Punjab Healthcare Commission laws and rules, Pakistan Medical Commission/medical ethics framework, Police Rules for medico-legal examination, and provincial health-department SOPs for gender-based violence survivors.

Part H — Constitutional and international protections

23. Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan

Official source: https://www.punjablaws.gov.pk/

Scope: Foundational rights applying to women in Punjab.

Key sections / provisions to include:

- Article 8: Laws inconsistent with fundamental rights to be void.
- Article 9: Security of person.
- Article 10A: Right to fair trial and due process.
- Article 11: Prohibition of slavery, forced labour and human trafficking.
- Article 14: Inviolability of dignity of man and privacy of home.
- Article 25: Equality of citizens and prohibition of discrimination on the basis of sex.
- Article 25A: Right to education.
- Article 27: Safeguard against discrimination in services.
- Article 34: Full participation of women in national life.
- Article 35: Protection of marriage, family, mother and child.

International commitments

Pakistan has committed to international human-rights standards including CEDAW, the Convention on the Rights of the Child, and SDG commitments on gender equality. These commitments support interpretation and implementation of domestic laws, though enforceable rights in Pakistani courts primarily arise from the Constitution and statutes.

Part I — Where to complain in Punjab

Situation	Forum / service	Contact
Domestic violence, stalking, abuse by husband/family	Punjab Women's Helpline / Women Protection Officer (24/7)	1043 (24/7)
Punjab Women Protection Authority	Complaint, referral and protection support	1737; 042-99333817; pwpa.official@pwpa.gov.pk
Workplace harassment	Workplace Inquiry Committee or FOSPAH	FOSPAH: 051-9218845; complaints@fospah.gov.pk
Online blackmail, fake photos, deepfakes, cyberstalking	FIA Cybercrime / cybercrime authorities	1991
Legal advice and human-rights violation	Ministry of Human Rights Helpline	1099; WhatsApp 0333-9085709
Acid attack or serious injury	Emergency services, hospital, police	Rescue 1122 / Police 15
Forced or child marriage	Police, Family Court, Child Protection authorities	1043 / Police 15
Property or inheritance usurpation	District administration, civil court, Punjab Enforcement of Women Property Rights Authority	Through Women Protection Authority / legal aid

Evidence checklist

For any case, preserve: CNIC copy, nikahnama, marriage registration, medical reports, medico-legal certificate, photographs, screenshots, chat records, call recordings, bank statements, property documents, witness names, police FIR copy, and dates/times of incidents.

Do not delete digital evidence. For online blackmail, keep the original device and account access where possible, and avoid paying or negotiating with the blackmailer.

Recommended structure for the full mega PDF

A practical full-text edition should be around 300–700 pages, depending on whether complete statutes are reproduced. The recommended structure is:

Chapter	Contents
1. Emergency guide	Immediate safety, helplines, evidence, FIR, medical help
2. Punjab violence law	Full Punjab Protection of Women against Violence Act, 2016, section-by-section
3. Punjab institutions	Punjab Women Protection Authority Act, 2017 and related rules
4. Workplace harassment	Protection Against Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2010, amended 2022
5. Criminal protection	Relevant PPC sections: rape, acid, stalking, harassment, kidnapping, honour crimes, intimidation
6. Cybercrime	PECA 2016 sections 20, 21, 24 and related provisions
7. Marriage and divorce	Muslim Family Laws Ordinance 1961; Dissolution of Muslim Marriages Act 1939; Punjab amendments
8. Forced and child marriage	PPC 498B; Child Marriage Restraint Act; Punjab Marriage Restraint Amendment Act 2015
9. Property and inheritance	Punjab Enforcement of Women Property Rights Act 2021; Partition Act; Land Revenue Act
10. Financial rights	Dower, maintenance, loans, banking complaints, women-entrepreneur schemes
11. Health and maternity	Maternity benefits, medical consent, medico-legal procedures, healthcare regulations
12. Employment	Maternity protection, workplace representation, child-labour protections
13. Complaint templates	FIR, FIA, FOSPAH, Family Court, protection-order application
14. Helplines and directories	Punjab and federal services, shelters, legal aid, hospitals

Important note

This handbook is legal information, not legal advice. Laws and procedural rules change; always verify the current version on Punjab Laws Online or with a lawyer before filing a case.